Publication discovery: launch SEO, previews and Preferred Sources

Strengths and best use

Search foundations make useful pages discoverable; clear previews help people recognize a shared page; Preferred Sources lets readers express an ongoing preference for a publication. These are complementary parts of a publishing workflow, each with its own eligibility and measurement. Google SEO starter guide (https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/seo-starter-guide)

Establish a crawlable publication

Give each useful page a stable URL, descriptive title, meaningful content, and internal links. Check canonical URLs, redirects, mobile rendering, and unintended blocking. Submit a sitemap of intended canonical pages through the relevant search tooling, then inspect indexing evidence. Sitemap submission helps discovery and does not guarantee indexing or ranking. Sitemap guide (https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/sitemaps/build-sitemap)

For participating engines, IndexNow can notify added, changed, and deleted URLs using a host-verified key. A successful receipt establishes that the notification arrived. Maintain accurate canonical URLs and inspect downstream crawl behavior. IndexNow documentation (https://www.indexnow.org/documentation)

Add appropriate Open Graph title, type, image, and canonical URL, plus a useful description. Preview the real shared page and verify that the image URL is accessible. A good social preview is independently useful even when it has no demonstrated search-ranking effect. Open Graph protocol (https://ogp.me/)

Offer Preferred Sources where eligible

Google's current guidance covers Top Stories and preferred-source features in AI Mode and AI Overviews. This extends the older Top-Stories-only description in the dossier. Domains or subdomains can qualify; a subdirectory is not the unit to submit. Check that the publication appears in the source picker and inspect the current AI-feature eligibility information in Search Console. Reader preference is not a guaranteed boost across ordinary results. Preferred Sources guidance (https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/preferred-sources)

For an eligible publication, replace the example domain in this reader-facing URL:

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https://www.google.com/preferences/source?q=example.com
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The documentation also offers a publisher button. Verify its current integration instructions and test the reader flow before installing it. Do not tell readers they have successfully added a source until the actual preference flow confirms it.

Measure distinct outcomes

Keep discovery, indexed pages, search impressions, clicks, preferred-source selections where observable, and conversions separate. Compare consistent date windows and distinguish a new content release from a preference-button change. Preserve baseline screenshots and records rather than attributing every traffic change to one feature.

Reusable prompt

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Audit this publication's canonical pages, internal links, sitemap, blocking rules, and social previews. Separately check Preferred Sources domain eligibility and the live reader flow. Propose a measurement plan that distinguishes crawl discovery, indexing, impressions, clicks, and conversions, preserving unknown attribution.
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Project idea

Create a launch-discovery checklist with one evidence row per URL and a separate preference-flow test. Use a small sample of real public pages before applying changes sitewide.

Original sources

- https://www.instagram.com/reel/DfP381BOVyh/
- https://www.instagram.com/reel/DeyBx9-vl0k/